

WARLOCK

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PRIESTHOOD

WARLOCK

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THE DEEP DIVINE: MASKS OF THE PRIESTHOOD

by Tim Hitchcock

Despite their best efforts, mortals will never understand the true nature of the universe, its state of perfect entropy. In wonder, fear, and desperation though, they petition the divine for such revelation, for the purposeful meaning of their existence. Nevertheless, even the gods do not divulge these secrets—and it is uncertain if they even could. They appear immortal only to the short-lived creatures of the mortal world, but to the vast infinity of the void, they too are only a blink in the eye of eternity.

One of the unique aspects of Midgard's pantheons is the inclusion of divine masks—different manifestations of the same deity. Within the game world, while priesthoods might accept that a deity could possess alternate manifestations, the idea of divine masks is little more than a fringe topic in theological discourse. But that doesn't mean a character can't explore the deep mysteries of their faith, bringing them, perhaps even unknowingly, to the doorstep of one of their deity's masks

Considering Masks. Within the game, these masks might represent a deity's manifestation during the transition from one stage of existence to another. And if time does work differently for the gods, the future and past quickly become irrelevant.

A divine mask might represent how a god appears depending on its followers: Veles, the great serpent, for instance, may appear in the guise of any god, and worshippers believe the serpent to be the only god and all other gods simply divine representations of Veles. Occasionally, a mask represents ideologies or practices contradicting or opposing the faith's primary tenets. For mortal worshippers, the dichotomy of structure and belief explains the occurrence of various events, such as cataclysms, war, disease, and death. It divorces deities from mortal conceptualizations of morality, implying the existence of a greater divine morality and creating a further distinction between deities and their mortal worshippers.

Assuming a Divine Mask

Within the priesthoods of every major religion, select clerics devote themselves to a deeper understanding of their deity. These clerics explore the intricacies and subtleties of the scriptures and attempt to decipher their meaning. Inevitably the search leads to lost or forbidden lore associated with the worship of their deity—and leading to the exploration of their deity's divine masks (see **Masks in Your Game** sidebar).

If a cleric character desires to explore the deep and often apocryphal mysteries of their deity (that is, their masks), choose a single god to designate as their primary god. Next, choose one domain associated with one of that deity's masks. This domain becomes the character's secondary domain. By attuning to a specially crafted focus mask, you can use Channel Divinity to shift your primary domain to the domain represented by the divine mask. In effect, you become a cleric of a different domain, though you maintain devotion to the same deity. You can only access a single domain at any given time.

Each cleric holds a profoundly intimate and personal relationship with their deity. Therefore, before creating and attuning to a focus mask, establish the character's reasoning for assuming such

a mask associated with the deity. Use the **Reason for Assuming a Mask** table (page 5) for inspiration.

Backlash

Not all priesthoods or religions acknowledge these deeper mysteries (or masks) for their chosen gods, and many clergy formally denounce their belief as sacrilege. Backlash



intensifies when individuals honor divine masks that espouse contradictory philosophies or openly challenge a priesthood's tenets. Conversely, the blasphemous concept that one's deity is mere divine mask or minor aspect of another deity demands confrontation. While the devout occasionally question their faith, they rarely tolerate when another priesthood claims their deity only exists as a mask. At best, they may accept or argue that another deity is a mask of their own deity. As a result, clerics that serve multiple aspects of the same deity often keep their practices covert. Depending on circumstances, a cleric assuming a divine mask may pretend to worship the mask's aspect as their primary deity or avoid assuming the mask altogether.

MASKS IN YOUR GAME

The idea of masks is a gaming device for when dealing with the gods of the Midgard campaign setting (see *Midgard Worldbook* for more information on masks). This abstraction of the gods is not really a topic that characters in Midgard would likely talk about or even comprehend, aside from perhaps in the most rarified conclaves of divinity scholars—certainly not among the common folk. The reality in the game world is that the beliefs and practices of the various religions merge and evolve in various combinations over time (known as syncretism). So a cleric character exploring a "mask" of their primary god is really just exploring the deep mysteries of that god's teachings, likely apocryphal, and might never actually intone or even consider the name of the mask deity while still benefiting from the corresponding alternate domains. The character would likely still view any newly espoused beliefs as belonging to their primary god.

We are, however, using the term *mask* here freely in relation to characters for the ease of incorporating the related mechanics should you choose to experiment with them.

Basics

A cleric that attains 3rd level gains access to the *imbue divine mask* spell. This allows you to delve into exploring various divine masks associated with your deity. The spell allows you to bless a specially crafted focus mask that establishes a divine connection to one of your patron deity's masks.

IMBUE DIVINE MASK

2nd-Level Divination (Ritual) | Cleric

Casting Time: 1 hour

Range: Touch

Components: V, S, M (a focus mask worth at least 250 gp, see text)

Duration: 1 day or until completing a long rest (see text)

When you cast this spell, you temporarily bless a specially crafted relic in the form of a focus mask that grants you the ability to commune with one divine mask associated with your primary deity. The focus mask represents an alternate manifestation of your primary deity, whose divine mask you wish to assume. Creating a focus mask requires unique woods, metals, gems, paints, and other materials that cost no less than 250 gp, takes a month to create, and requires proficiency in an appropriate set of tools for the crafting.

After creating the focus mask, you imbue it with a divine enchantment, allowing you to attune to a divine mask associated with your patron deity. The focus mask is associated with a specific deity and establishes your bond to that deity. The focus mask is considered a holy item as long as the blessing remains. It serves as your personalized divine focus, and only the caster who created it may use it effectively. The enchantment lasts until you cast the spell upon another focus mask or your focus mask is destroyed. After that, you may attune to the focus mask and use it as a magic item.

REASON FOR ASSUMING A MASK

d6	REASON
1	You assume a different incarnation of the same character, a sort of split soul, perhaps even shifting through time and space.
2	You experience a wild personality shift. When you assume the mask, you have no memory of your previous personality.
3	You believe the divine mask to be the true form of your deity. The revelation occurred after you first assumed the focus mask.
4	You believe the divine mask connects your deity to ancient philosophies, which you must somehow sever. Unfortunately, you must assume the focus mask to help break those cosmic bindings.
5	You believe you must spend time serving each of your deity's opposing divine masks to help maintain cosmic balance.
6	You worship a deity shunned or despised by the dominant culture and assume their divine mask to covertly continue your services to the priesthood and other followers of your faith.

Once attuned to the focus mask, you can spend one use of your Channel Divinity class ability to become an agent of your deity's divine mask. Then, you temporarily sever your connection to your primary domain (your chosen cleric domain) and bind yourself to a secondary domain associated with one of your patron deity's divine masks. While bonded to the secondary domain, you replace all the domain spells and domain powers associated with your primary domain with all the domain spells and domain powers associated with the appropriate divine mask. In effect, you temporarily switch domains while retaining your connection to your chosen deity.

Assuming a focus mask requires near-blind devotion and absolute surrender to the whims of your deity. You assume the role of the deity's mortal vessel and accept the manifestation of multiple masks. Whenever a cleric shifts focus masks, they invoke a struggle between fate and independence. Each divine mask carries distinct obligations. This can also introduce moral challenges when divine masks of the same deity do not share the same alignments or values and do not make the same moral distinctions.

Wearing a divine mask for too long may cause a cleric to lose their primary domain

and permanently shift to the secondary domain associated with the divine mask. A divine mask can only be worn for a day or until you complete a long rest. To avoid the risk of losing your primary domain (chosen cleric domain), you must wait at least a week before assuming the divine mask again. If you assume the divine mask before a week passes, you must succeed on a DC 10 Charisma saving throw or permanently lose your primary domain's spells and powers. The domain associated with your deity's divine mask replaces your original domain. If the alignment associated with the divine mask is different from your alignment, it shifts to reflect the values of the divine mask. On a successful save, you can remove the focus mask. However, each additional day you assume the divine mask increases the DC to lose your primary domain by +1. In effect, clerics who continue to assume the belief systems associated with a specific mask incur a permanent shift in their beliefs.

A cleric incurring a permanent shift in their beliefs loses access to the domain power of their former primary domain. After that, they can never assume the divine mask associated with the domain they forsook. Any further attempts to assume the mask anger the deity. If the character wants to continue being a

cleric, they must perform a series of ritual penances to regain the deity's favor or find a new patron deity altogether.

PENANCE

A cleric seeking to reestablish a connection with their deity's primary mask chooses to represent their former domain. To regain favor, they must perform one or more of the following acts in penance.

Convert. The cleric must prove the sincerity of their devotion by converting outsiders into the deity's service. The number of followers should be of an equal CR to the cleric's level plus their proficiency bonus.

Founding. To increase the deity's influence, the cleric must build a foundation dedicated to the deity that provides community service. Typically, the establishment of a church or temple. However, if the settlement has a church or temple, the deity may request the establishment of a hostel, mission, or orphanage.

Quest. The cleric must undertake a quest to prove their sincerity. Quests may include recovering a relic, pilgrimage to a sacred site, leading followers to a new and more fruitful

location, or irradiating the influence of a rival deity.

DIVINE INTERVENTION AND MASKS

Once you assume a divine mask, the connection to an alternate sphere of influence also influences the 10th-level Divine Intervention ability. Whenever you use the ability to call upon your patron deity, you cannot be sure which of your patron's divine masks will answer. Each divine mask you access increases the probability that any associated mask hears your petition. However, different mask aspects likely interpret petitions in ways that create unintended consequences. Consequences vary according to the philosophy and alignment of the divine mask.

When you roll your Divine Intervention check, you roll a d20 for your primary domain and a d20 for each divine mask you have ever assumed. The lowest roll represents the mask that manifests to offer assistance.

If the lowest roll is your primary domain, the Divine Intervention functions normally. If not, consult the **Unintended Consequences** table below.

UNINTENDED CONSEQUENCES

d8 CONSEQUENCES	
1	The mask refuses to speak to you until you activate your focus mask and attune to their domain.
2	The divine mask demands some sort of tribute or sacrifice in exchange for granting the request. The tribute or sacrifice should be proportional to the request.
3	The mask is capricious or fickle and withholds a tiny element of the request without first bothering to inform you of the alteration.
4	The divine mask grants the request but then demands you never again call upon them for aid. As a result, your focus mask crumbles to dust, and you can never again communicate with that aspect of your deity.
5	The mask offers the aid but expects you to perform a favor or quest in return.
6	The divine mask requests you forsake your current primary domain and instead patronize the divine mask as your primary domain.
7	After granting the request, the deity temporarily cuts off all access to your Channel Divinity until you take a long rest.
8	The mask severs your access to all domain powers associated with their primary domain until you take a long rest.

MASKED PRIESTHOODS

While an individual cleric might explore the facets of a deity's masks independently, entire priesthoods are devoted to worshipping their deity's every aspect. These masked priesthoods represent cults or sects that create a dichotomy within a religion's foundational tenets. The critical element to building a masked priesthood requires the struggle of the duality between two (or more) distinct philosophies and coming to terms with that balance as a servant of that deity.

The Midgard campaign setting has many deities, with each entry containing a section describing the deity's specific masks. A mask often represents regional and cultural differences between similar deities and reflects how the same entity might appear to different peoples. A good example is the northern deities Freyr and Freya who appear as Yarla and Porevit to elven counterparts. The tripartite deities Thor, Perun, and Mavros offer another example of this type of relationship. While this makes for colorful storytelling, neither of these examples make good candidates for building a masked priesthood because they lack conflict between their counterparts.

Similarly, the belief that all deities exist as aspects of one grand deity (as with Veles, the Great Serpent) makes a poor choice for building a masked priesthood. The core assumption of a monotheistic deity that appears in many forms to all beings overrides a need for covert duality. There is no conflict between sects and beliefs, and all philosophical conflict becomes inner conflict and explains the convoluted nature of reality, which can be all things and one thing.

SAMPLE MASKED PRIESTHOODS IN MIDGARD

Below are some examples of masked priesthoods. It is important to note that the following mask lists are examples only to illustrate how the relationships between

masks might appear in your game. The Goat of the Woods, Hecate, and Loki hold no greater importance—unless perhaps you number among their faithful—than those listed as their masks, for in truth they are masks themselves. These lists could have easily been that of Ninkash, Thoth-Hermes, and Baal or any number of other pairings.

GOAT OF THE WOODS

The masks of the Goat represent the ancient deity's progression from one eon to the next. However, the older beliefs still cling even through the transformation and occasionally surface when triggered by need or circumstance. Alternatively, priests most dedicated to the Goat and her primal and savage rites use the masks of her later incarnations to hide within society and infiltrate current cultures more effectively.

Bacchana. Clerics of this priesthood believe Bacchana represents the Goat of the Woods during another age before she became corrupted and alien. Clerics attune to the domains of Lust or Prophecy

Ninkash. In recent years, some claim that Ninkash, the deity of drunken mirth, is a mask of the Goat of the Woods. Many find the claim ironic, considering the rivalry between Ninkash and Baccho. Still, there remains an undeniable connection between drunken celebration, debauchery, and regret. Clerics of this priesthood attune to the domains of either Beer or Life.

Vardesain. This masked priesthood believes that the Goat of the Woods assumes the mask of Vardesain when she seeks to communicate with the void. They believe the mask of Vardesain is an incarnation of the Goat and one of her many spawns. Clerics of the Goat of the Woods who assume Vardesain's mask use it to attune to the Void domain.

HECATE

Magic is by nature wondrous and sinister, and its mysteries frequently lie hidden in dark and disturbing origins. Worshipers of



Hecate hold their goddess as the sum of all these mysteries. Each mystery represents the embodiment of one of her many masks. The following examples present some of the masks to which a priesthood of Hecate might attune.

Azuran. The draconic god of the four winds connects the magical forces between sky and earth. Clerics of this masked priesthood often assume the mask of Azuran during the day and return to Hecate when her blessed moon rises. Human clerics attune to the domains of Speed and War while dragonkin worshippers attune to the Dragon domain. Alternatively, dragonkin believe Hecate is a mask of Azuran.

Marena. Marena, the red goddess, represents Hecate's attunement to magic derived from fear and death. Clerics dedicated to Marena's mask acknowledge Hecate's connection with depravity and unspeakable evils. The masked priesthood typically attunes to the Death domain, but those following a more primal expression of magic attune to the domain of Lust.

Seggotan. Like Azuran, this priesthood views Seggotan's mask as Hecate's connection to the elemental magic of water. Clerics of this priesthood attune to the Tempest or Water domains.

Thoth-Hermes. Hecate typically manifests as a city god, though she can quickly spread her reach beyond city walls. Clerics of this masked priesthood assume the mask of Thoth-Hermes when wandering the world and frequently attune to the Travel domain.

LOKI

Loki is a great deity to use to build a masked priesthood. As the trickster god, he changes his appearance, never manifesting as expected. It lies in the nature of his priesthood for members to assume alternate guises and wear the masks of other beings manipulated by Loki. Conversely, sinister deities such as

Chernobog assume the mask of the trickster to appear less monstrous or deviant in their intentions. They don Loki's mask and disguise their intentions' foulness by intertwining them with the trickster's playful pranks. The following examples focus on priesthoods that might choose Loki as a mask.

Baal. Loki represents a human aspect of Baal, a blasphemous belief within the Dragon Empire. Of all deities that assume Loki's mask, Baal is the most philosophically dissonant. Clerics of this priesthood believe a link between Chaos and Law allows Baal to maintain cosmic balance. Therefore, they typically choose Knowledge or Trickery as their secondary domains.

Chernobog. Death and darkness often hide secrets. Clerics of this priesthood believe that Chernobog's command of fear lies in his ability to disrupt reality. Clerics of Chernobog who assume Loki's mask use it to attune to the Trickery or Knowledge Domain. Priesthoods concerned with bringing death to all things use Loki's mask to assume his role as the bringer of Ragnarok and attune to the Apocalypse domain.

Sarastra. The goddess of the shadow Fey and realms of illusion needs to manifest in many forms, especially when she must confront mortals who might question or distrust her motives. The priesthood's clerics assume Loki's mask to attune to the Travel domain.

Thoth-Hermes. Clerics of this priesthood focus their concerns on uncovering lore, knowledge, and power. The priesthood attunes to Knowledge as their secondary domain.

Veles. The Midgard serpent takes many forms. Clerics of this priesthood believe that Veles sometimes uses the mask of the trickster to appear before mortals he seeks to tempt, trick, or otherwise deceive. Clerics of Veles who assume Loki's mask use it to attune to the Trickery domain.

SERVANTS TO THE GODS: FAITH IN THE CROSSROADS

by Sebastian Rombach

From Ariadne, the Clockwork Oracle, to Wotan, the All-Father, the gods of Midgard are as majestic as they are varied. But as legendary as the myths of the gods are, their gospels carry little weight without servants to spread their dogma. Among the common folk of Midgard, worship is as often a collective experience as it is a solitary one, steeped in generations of practice, service, and tradition. Let's look at a few of these servants, how they congregate, and how their piety affects those around them.

Polytheism in Midgard

Midgard is a world where polytheism is the primary way mortals view divinity. Pantheons are separated by region, godly individuals by their focus, and nearly all of them are worshipped by most mortals. From the gods' perspective, who is receiving worship from whom is obscured by the use of masks (see *Midgard Worldbook*). But the vast majority of folks remain largely unaware of such deceptions. Instead, mortals worship the gods they believe in, in their own way regardless of what lies behind the heavenly curtain.

To address how characters might express reverence and piety, you can look to the actual practices of polytheism. Though the study of any theology can be a lifelong pursuit, there

are two schools of polytheistic thought—hard polytheism and soft polytheism—that can be used as launching points for lending nuance and verisimilitude to characters.

Hard Polytheism. Hard polytheism is defined by the solid belief that each deity is separate and distinct. Hard, or steadfast, polytheists are defined by their belief and conviction in what the gods are, what they want, and what they offer.

Characters that subscribe to hard polytheism regularly seek others of like mind to congregate with, attempt to win over those who are undecided, and shun those who oppose their views. When a steadfast polytheist's beliefs are destabilized, such as a debunked miracle or a religious leader revealed for a fraud, their reactions are often dramatic and occasionally extreme.

Soft polytheism. Soft polytheism is, in contrast, somewhat easygoing. Individuals who practice this type of faith believe that the divine beings fill more archetypal roles in accordance with mortal conditions or beliefs rather than rigid definitions. Soft, or flexible, polytheists are only a few leaps of logic away from understanding how the gods use masks to achieve their goals, or they would if they believed that the gods were actual beings. The pitfall of soft polytheism is its tendency

toward reductivism. Soft polytheism comes with an inbuilt assumption of agnosticism or even atheism that is diametrically opposed to the will of the gods themselves. Characters who subscribe to this theology are more open-minded and sometimes more thoughtful, reverent even, but much less pious than characters at the opposing end of the spectrum. At their worst, soft polytheists are implacable skeptics who, no matter the evidence, will always seek to explain away miracles and divine experiences.

Religion in the Crossroads

The Crossroads region is aptly named where gods and their worshippers are concerned. No community here is inured to the genesis of new faiths or the exodus of the obsolete. Hard and soft polytheism, pantheism, atheism, and agnosticism abound in equal measure.

This revolving door of divinity means no end of confusion and conflict where religious beliefs are concerned. But rather than engage in outright crusades against each other, the major faiths of the Crossroads develop rivalries over attendance and hierarchy while fostering alliances over shared interests.

These faiths know that to gain followers they must continually manifest miracles to establish and reinforce belief. The gods know this too. Consequently, nearly all the gods are more direct with their priests here than elsewhere in Midgard, providing divine power and blessings to captivate hearts and minds.

Keeping the peace is a difficult, multipronged task in this religious landscape. Because of the complexities of interfaith relations, the religious orders of Khors, Lada, Perun, Rava, and Volund periodically meet to address mounting concerns, reassess old accords, and occasionally bury the hatchet. In this way, a quietly organized committee called the Clergy of Carrefour Faiths works from the shadows.

Clergy of Carrefour Faiths

Founded by select representatives from the major religious orders of the Crossroads, the Clergy of Carrefour Faiths is a roundtable sect devoted to caretaking the religious-political balance while maintaining anonymity from the public eye.

The clergy itself is represented by no more than five chapters at any given time, meeting in secret and only once in a season in the Ironcrag, Magdar Kingdom, the Black Hills, Perunalia, and near Zobeck. Only in occasions of dire peril do all the chapters meet at once, when the needs outweigh the risks of exposure. With the clergy spread out across the Crossroads, each chapter is led by five representatives called Clovers—a priest each from the faiths that follow the major gods of the Crossroads Pantheon. In addition to these five seats, each chapter hosts a skeleton crew of spy-priests that gather information and carry out the Clovers' directives.

Members of the clergy recognize each other by a mark, pin, or some other affectation that depicts a three-leaved clover enveloped in a green and copper ribbon. The Clovers of each chapter also wear enchanted brooches in the same style that prevents the wearer from deceiving another brooch-wearing Clover. This enchantment helps to ensure the integrity of the clergy is maintained against personal interests.

With such wide ground to cover and many religious interests present at any given time, the clergy's focus is limited to only a few, albeit vital, tasks. The Clovers and their secret priests verify miracles, dispense justice upon oathbreakers, and silence heresy in their own religions. To ensure that these goals are met with satisfaction by the entire clergy, each Clover is responsible for addressing the violations of members from their own religious orders only and to honestly report their successes and failures to their peer Clovers. The very structure of the Clergy of

Carrefour Faiths was founded to prevent one god's adherents from interfering with the internal conflicts of another. At least, directly.

All members are sworn to secrecy and take solemn, binding oaths. To a member, nothing is more sacred than a kept vow and nothing more profane than a broken one.

OATH DOMAIN (DIVINE DOMAIN)

Vows are not to be made lightly. Seek out and castigate those who would break their word.

Whether by divine mandate, personal devotion, or ministerial duty, you have taken on the solemn burden of holding others to their vows and punishing those who break them. Clerics who take this domain are warily regarded, even feared, as inescapable inquisitors. Some clerics choose this domain to hunt down oath-breaking paladins and bring them to justice, and others might serve religious governments and organizations as inquisitors, lawmakers, or even spies. Regardless of your motivations, you know that while words hold power, vows carry authority.

CLERIC LEVEL	SPELLS
1st	<i>command, insightful maneuver*</i>
3rd	<i>hold person, zone of truth</i>
5th	<i>compelling fate*, speak with dead</i>
7th	<i>banishment, compulsion</i>
9th	<i>geas, tongue tied*</i>

(*) see *Deep Magic*.

OATH AND INQUISITION

At 1st level, you gain proficiency in Investigation as well as with whips and warhammers. You also learn one language of your choice.

CHANNEL DIVINITY: VOW OF CONFESSION

Starting at 2nd level, you can use your Channel Divinity to compel others to swear an oath against their actions.

As an action, you can present your holy symbol and speak a phrase of authority.

Choose any number of creatures within 30 feet of you equal to your proficiency bonus + your Wisdom modifier (minimum 1). A targeted creature must succeed on a Charisma saving throw or drop what they are holding and spend their reaction reciting a promise, vow, bond, or oath they have made in their lifetime. Any creature that does not share a language with you has advantage on their saving throw. Creatures who do not have a language or have an Intelligence less than 8 are not affected.

CHANNEL DIVINITY: HOLDING WORD

Starting at 6th level, you can use your Channel Divinity to hold someone's actions and words against them. Choose one creature within 60 feet of you that you can see and that can hear you. That creature must make a Wisdom saving throw. On a successful save, the creature's movement speed is halved until the end of its next turn. On a failed save, choose a number of actions equal to your proficiency bonus (Attack, Cast a Spell, Dash, Disengage, Dodge, Help, Hide, Ready, Search, Use An Object). The creature is unable to take those actions for a minute. The creature repeats their saving throw at the end of their turn, ending the effect on a success.

Humanoids who have broken their word or violated an oath within a year and a day have disadvantage on their saving throws against this feature. Creatures who do not have a language or have an Intelligence less than 8 are not affected.

POTENT SPELLCASTING

Starting at 8th level, you add your Wisdom modifier to the damage you deal with cantrips.

THOUGHTS AND PRAYERS

At 17th level, when you are subject to an effect that allows you to make an Intelligence, Wisdom, or Charisma saving throw for half damage, you instead take no damage on a success or half damage on a failure, provided that the effect has a verbal component that

you can hear. Additionally, you can expend a spell slot of 1st to 4th level to gain telepathy to a range of 60 feet for 10 minutes, a slot of 5th to 8th level for 1 hour, or a slot of 9th level for 24 hours.

Order of Unbridled Waves

The Order of Unbridled Waves is a brotherhood of coastal priests and maritime cavaliers who worship Nethus, King of the Sea, and proselytize the bounties of his faith. Commissioned by Ocean Seer Qorette Mardefon, High Priest of Nethus, the order's mandate is as clear as calm waters and follows a hard polytheistic approach. Honor Nethus and the tribulations of his bondage by ensuring liberty and freedom for all.

The order, still in its infancy, indiscriminately accepts membership from any who seek admission. More than a few outsiders voice skepticism of this policy though. The order's detractors point to the lax vetting of prospective members, claiming rotten fish ruin the whole catch. But members of the order rebuke these criticisms. The order requires all initiates to take solemn oaths that echo the pledge Nethus is believed to have made for his freedom.

In addition to these oaths, new members are expected to perform a ceremony called the Vigil of Night Tides, honoring the matrimonial vows Nethus made to Hecate, Queen of Night. The task entails sailing outward amid a full moon, submersing oneself in the night-lit waters, and enduring what comes until dawn's first light concludes the ritual. The especially fortunate are visited by giant seahorses who bear the vigilant persons safely back, a blessing from the Lord of Fish and Whales himself.

The order, while based in Capleon and assisting with the Steps of the Sea's reconstruction, sends its new recruits out across open waters on a pilgrimage of exploration. These priests come from all walks of life, whether they were sailors or

gladiators, prisoners or slaves. Every member is welcomed into the order and trusted with the same duty: crusade in the name of freedom, for the good of the innocent and the worthy.

In everyday affairs, laypeople of the order serve as advocates in domestic and maritime disputes, provide refuge for the pursued, and dispense blessings such as the christenings of new sea vessels.

OATH OF TIDES (SACRED OATH)

Break the chains that anchor you in place and pledge your freedom on open waters.

The Oath of Tides calls for paladins to embody the tempestuous majesty of the sea. Like unpredictable ocean currents, paladins who follow this oath tend toward neutral and chaotic alignments. Many of those who take the Oath of Tides suffered under some form of bondage but found freedom and purpose in personifying the uncontainable sea.

TENETS OF TIDES

The Oath of Tides borrows its tenets from sea shanties sung by wistful sailors and warrior-poets compelled by ocean splendors. Paladins who uphold these tenets remember their origins, especially that which held them back, to move past the razor shoals of old history. Tidesworn paladins must strive to keep the wind in their sails as they explore life's deep mysteries and press ever onward. The Oath of Tides asks those who swear it to overcome their obstacles, pursue new avenues, and cut loose whatever weighs them down.

Chase the Horizon. Let my travels follow the stars and honor the moon. Through self-sacrifice, I free my heart to find my fortune.

Cherish Life's Ripples. All of life is a stream, a river, a sea. While I yet breathe, I will revel in and cherish thee.

Douse the Enemy. Let my foes cower behind their walls. I still shall crash upon them, drown them, quash them all.

Keep Unfettered. So long as my heart swells in my breast, let no barrier, chain, or obstacle do me arrest.

OATH SPELLS

You gain oath spells at the paladin levels listed.

PALADIN LEVEL	SPELLS
3rd	<i>create or destroy water, expeditious retreat</i>
5th	<i>find steed, shatter</i>
7th	<i>water breathing, water walk</i>
9th	<i>control water, freedom of movement</i>
17th	<i>conjure elemental (water only), exsangui-nate*</i>

(*) see *Deep Magic*.

CHANNEL DIVINITY

At 3rd level, you gain the following Channel Divinity options.

Rebuke the Deep. As an action, you present your holy symbol and speak a prayer, censuring sea creatures. Each beast, fey, humanoid, or monstrosity of your choice that can breathe underwater or that has a swim speed within 30 feet of you and can see or hear you must succeed a Wisdom saving throw or be turned for 1 minute or until it takes damage.

A turned creature must spend its turns trying to move as far away from you as it can, and it can't willingly move to a space within 30 feet of you. It also can't take reactions. For its action, it can use only the Dash action or try to escape from an effect that prevents it from moving. If there's nowhere to move, the creature can use the Dodge action.

Torrential Surge. As an action, you present your holy symbol or slam a melee weapon down before you to conjure a surging wave of water that flows away from you in a 20-foot cone. Any creature that is no more than one size category larger than you caught within the cone must make a Strength saving throw or be knocked back 20 feet and fall prone. On a successful saving throw, a creature is only knocked back 10 feet and does not fall prone. Any creature that is knocked into an object, such as a wall or column, takes 1d6 bludgeoning damage for every 5 feet traveled. A target knocked back this way does not incur opportunity attacks.



SLIPSTREAM AURA

Starting at 7th level, you gain a swim speed equal to your movement speed. Additionally, allies within 10 feet of you begin their turn with a swim speed equal to yours and can spend a bonus action to Dash.

At 18th level, the range of this aura increases to 30 feet.

ROLLING TIDES

Starting at 15th level, the waves you create surge and recede like the tides. When you use *Torrential Surge*, you create a second wave that pulls creatures back toward you, prompting a second saving throw from any creature caught in the effect. If a creature fails both of its saving throws, they are overcome with sea sickness and are poisoned until the end of its next turn.

TYPHOON CHAMPION

At 20th level, you take on aspects of a sea deity. Your skin carries the sheen of seawater, your hair stays damp and flows in thick waves, and your features take on fish-like exaggerations while you are bathed in moonlight.

By using an action, you can summon a swirling typhoon (or a whirlpool if underwater) centered on yourself. The typhoon lasts for 10 minutes or until you dismiss it (as a bonus action) and follows you around, granting the following benefits:

- As an action, you can target one creature within the typhoon's radius and knock the wind out of them, possibly causing targets to suffocate or drown. The target must make a Constitution saving throw or run out of breath. While breathless, targets are unable to speak or cast spells with verbal components and have disadvantage on attack rolls and skill checks. A breathless target can repeat their saving throw at the end of their turn, ending the effect on a success or by exiting the radius of the typhoon. Constructs, oozes, and undead are unaffected by this effect.

- At the start of each of your turns, you regain 10 hit points.
- Wind and water swirl around you in a 60-foot radius, making the area difficult terrain. Any creatures affected by your Slipstream Aura ignore the difficult terrain.
- Your melee attacks deal an additional 1d8 bludgeoning damage and knock Large and smaller targets back 5 feet. A target knocked back in this way does not incur opportunity attacks.

Once you use this feature, you can't use it again until you finish a long rest.

Servants of the Storm Lords

Among the religions, cults, and secret orders of Midgard, none are as bombastic as those who worship the gods of thunder, lightning, and battle.

Mavros, Thor, and Perun all command similar levels of fanaticism and expect similar rituals and sacrifices. What separates the tempest gods in the eyes of their followers is how they are worshipped and what ideals they value above others.

The Order of Mavros, an exceptionally regimented and expansive religious organization, preaches foremost on waging war. But partaking in war is not enough for Mavrites. The need to emerge victorious, to do so with honor, and to respect the opponent and the trappings of war itself are recurring themes in the order's sermons and doctrine. To a follower of Mavros, lightning-swift strikes and the thunder of battle are their prayers and hymns.

This focus on war, however, actually contrasts with how the Northlanders exalt Thor. Followers of the Thunderer place higher importance on slaying monsters and earning their glory from personal deeds. So too are Thor's followers more solitary in nature, eschewing large, regularly attended congregations for more intimate offerings to

THE PARABLE OF PERUN'S GIFT

For Perun's faithful, it is not enough to simply make war. A common parable called "Perun's Gift" illustrates this.

The parable teaches that when Perun saw that life was stagnant, he "gifted" the plains with lightning storms. These lightning storms in turn caused wildfires, laying waste to everything aground and driving all creatures away. Perun's enemies and allies alike learned to fear him for this. But when the

thunderstorms calmed and the ashes dispersed, new plantings budded, and saplings revealed themselves beneath the scorched brush. The new growth in turn attracted hale creatures. Before long the land was renewed with vigor, brighter and more vibrant than ever before.

The moral behind Perun's Gift is that Perun's wrath is actually a blessing and that conflict is necessary for spiritual, and literal, growth.

shrines and after hunts, personal moments of piety during storms, and dedications of glory in the face of perilous encounters.

While Mavrites seek to honor their god through their actions, followers of Thor seek to emulate the Thunderer himself, striving to become like him in their own deeds.

And the servants of Perun? Many Perunites seek war and action like the Order of Mavros while others dance and taunt the rain like Thor's followers. And in fact, every priest of each Storm Lord will find cause to practice like the priests of the other. But some servants of Perun prefer to ponder on the duality, the polarity, that Perun symbolizes as the lord of both strife and rebirth.

While understanding the cause and effect of conflict is worthwhile, many Perunites see such studies of harmony as a waste of time. The mainstream Perunite doctrine preaches war as the worthiest of goals. But places like the Thunderbolt Monastery exist for those who are open to Perun's deeper meanings.

THUNDERBOLT MONASTERY

A cloistered hermitage resting on a peak in the northern spur of the White Mountains, not far from the White Wood, nestled on the White Road ley line, the Thunderbolt Monastery functions as a lightning rod for spiritual and climatic activity. Under the leadership of Grandmaster Hymolt,

monks here spend their lives studying the monastery's extensive library of historical and religious writings. Adhering to a flexible polytheistic approach, the monks chiefly worship Perun but also the various aspects of divinity as it manifests in war, thunder, and lightning. It's believed that the monastery keeps a one-of-a-kind copy of the *Annals of Mavros*, an apocryphal scripture supposedly cataloging prophecies that predicted all of Mavros's Great Saints and the coming of many more, though none at the monastery choose to confirm this rumor.

The monastery itself is actually a system of three buildings interconnected by roughhewn mountainous tunnels. Reaching the monastery requires a steep hike through scree, charred trees, and winding switchbacks, often through the mudslide-inducing rainstorms that frequent the locale.

Despite being devout worshippers of the gods of thunder and war, the monks are ill-regarded by members of the House of Swords for their differing approaches to piety. The House of Swords sees the monastery as a place of cowardice, bordering on heresy, for the latter's unwillingness to get directly involved with countrywide conflicts. Truthfully, the monastery holds no policy against violence or war. They simply consider their responsibility to keep wartime records a higher priority.

Privately, many high-ranking priests and political leaders from the Seven Cities and the Crossroads journey to the monastery seeking insight or to report wartime developments for the monastery's scribes.

While waiting for these clandestine visits to conclude, the visitors' entourages are invited to observe a rare treat. In addition to their historical duties, the monks of Thunderbolt Monastery practice a unique form of martial art, manifesting primal forces through their very bodies. Witnessing these fervent practices, more than one visiting warrior has stayed behind to exchange battle knowledge. So too do plenty of monks accompany dignitaries when their visits conclude, hoping to see the wider world of Midgard and gain first-hand accounts from battlefronts and war rooms.

Grandmaster Hymolt. Hymolt Goslarssen is a man of deep thought and outspoken opinion. Unlike his predecessor, Vicello Falderan, who preferred to maintain a certain political balance, Hymolt is a man who brashly says what he thinks, no matter who or what the subject might be. Though his thick accent betrays his non-nativity to the region, his bombastic persona has earned him unwavering devotion from his fellow monks and the begrudging respect of the Seven Cities' numerous war leaders. His most noteworthy work is the *Chronica Tonitrum*, a compiled history of the Seven Cities' many conflicts and their religious significance. Though treated as scripture by Hymolt's monks, the account is oft-maligned (typically by those it critiques) for its scathing annotations that point out political missteps and military blunders. A fierce and disciplined combatant, both in debate and in combat, Hymolt is unforgiving of those who choose to hide their mistakes rather than own them.

WAY OF THE STORM (MONASTIC TRADITION)

Gather yourself like a cloud on the horizon and strike with the sudden fury of the heavens.

Monks who practice the Way of the Storm are living fonts of storm energy, tapping into the wellsprings within themselves to conjure powers attributed to deities of tempests and battle fury. What mages spend lifetimes of studying esoterica to achieve, storm monks learn to do through intensive contemplation, religious study, and rigorous training.

Their doctrine holds that the ki within us all is a measure of divinity, and it is up to the individual to learn to access it. Monks who practice this tradition seek to transcend the limits of their mortal coil to become living lightning rods, scouring the battlefield with fistfuls of lightning while leaving charred foes and sonic booms in their wake.

BONUS PROFICIENCIES

At 3rd level, you gain proficiency in Religion. You also gain proficiency with calligrapher's supplies.

SPARKING STRIKES

Starting at 3rd level, you learn to draw upon the storm inside you to empower your blows. Whenever you expend ki, your attacks deal additional lightning or thunder damage (your choice) equal to your proficiency bonus until the beginning of your next turn. Any creature within 5 feet of a target you hit with this feature also takes the additional lightning or thunder damage.

STORM'S DISCIPLE

Starting at 6th level, your connection to your inner storm swells as you gain new ways to expend ki.

Discharging Rebuke. When a creature hits you with a melee attack, you can spend 1 or more ki points as a reaction, forcing that creature to make a Dexterity saving throw. On a failed save, the target takes lightning damage equal to the result of your martial arts

die per point of ki expended. On a successful save, the target takes half as much damage. You can never spend more ki points than your proficiency bonus in this way.

Lightning Reach. You can expend 2 ki points as part of a ranged weapon attack to double the weapon's range. Unless the weapon is ammunition, broken, or held by another creature, it returns to your hand at the beginning of your next turn.

VOLTAIC SOUL

At 11th level, you've learned how to move with the storm and how to let it move through you, mastering the pain to recharge your spirit. Whenever you take lightning damage, you regain 1 ki point. Whenever you take thunder damage, you can immediately use your reaction to use your Step of the Wind feature at no ki cost.

TURBULENT STEP

At 17th level, whenever you use your full movement on your turn, you can take an action to expend 4 ki points and create a 30-foot cone of thunderous force aimed behind you. The cone originates after you have come to a stop. All creatures caught within the cone must make a Constitution saving throw, taking 8d8 thunder damage and being deafened until the end of their next turn on a failed save or half as much damage and no additional effects on a successful one.

Rites of the Crossroads

Each god is honored with rituals and sacrifices according to their own principles, yet many of the faithful in the Crossroads share common ground in religious rites and rituals.

BLESS FEAST

Prerequisite: Requires a Holy Symbol and a Pound of Fresh Food per Person

Fellowship takes many forms: spending time together in public prayer when Khors has hidden the sun behind overcast skies for too

many weeks, Volund-worshipping friars basking in the heat from a roaring forge and quenching a still red-hot blade in their sweat, dwarves passed out from a night of merriment and ale, "gone to visit Ninkash." What makes a feast so sacred is that it is a shared act, not a solitary one. For travelers who frequent the Sultan's Road, a blessed meal holds the most significance.

Characters that share a fresh meal (rations are unfit as a sacred offering) benefit from a blessing called Volund's Sjelevarme, which lasts for 24 hours. While under the effect of this blessing, a character has advantage on death saving throws and saving throws against fear, provided they are within at least 60 feet of someone else with whom they shared the meal.

EXPUL SPIRITS

Prerequisite: Requires Proficiency in Religion and a Holy Symbol

When Turn Undead or the *dispel evil and good* spell are unavailable or inadequate, other measures may be required to end a possession. To do so, a character must make a series of checks with a DC determined by how tenacious the possession is.

The character makes three checks: Intelligence (Religion), Wisdom (Religion), and a special Charisma check that has a bonus equal to a roll of the character's largest Hit Die (this roll doesn't spend that die). The DC for each of the checks is determined by the possessing creature's CR + 1d6 + 10. Generate a separate DC for each one.

If the character succeeds on two or more checks, the possession ends, and any spirit present is driven out and away as if by a cleric's Turn Undead. If the character fails on two or more, the possession becomes entrenched, and any further attempts to expel the possessing spirit automatically fail for the next 24 hours. Allies can use the Help action to assist, but they may have to contend with any complications. Intimate knowledge

of the possessing spirit or demon, such as a true name or hidden secret, could potentially provide advantage on one of the checks.

Complications. Possessions are challenging under the best of circumstances. A creature that doesn't want to give up its host will most likely retaliate against those performing the ritual as well as anyone else present. After each check is made, roll a d6 and consult the **Possession Complications** table below to see what complications characters might have to deal with. If a complication calls for a saving throw or skill check, the DC is the same as the previous check.

SANCTIFY LAND

Prerequisite: Requires the Ability to Cast Divine Spells

With intense prayer and devotion, a place or thing can be sanctified. This becomes a regular duty for those priests charged with the caretaking of holy sites, shrines, and temple sanctuaries. Altars, mausoleums, and sepulchers are also frequent targets, especially if intrusion or unholy resurrection is a risk.

While not as powerful as higher-level divine magic, a divine spellcaster can spend a short rest in prayer and the preparation of material sacrifice to achieve a similar magical effect.

After spending a short rest in prayer, roll percentile dice. If you roll a number equal to or lower than your character level, you are

successful, and any items you sacrificed are used up. You may then choose one secondary effect from the *hallow* spell, which then stays in effect for a week or until dispelled. For every 10 gp you spend in sacrificed material you add 5 to your character level for the purpose of this rite.

Holy Orders

Holy orders are typically a temple's official recognition of a paladin's oath, a priest or cleric's ordination, the crowning of royalty, or the marking of an important event. Holy orders differ greatly based on the deity of the religious persons conducting them. Here are holy order rituals you might bear witness to while in the Crossroads.

Khorsicans. The most common holy orders for Khors's faithful are the ones received when being knighted in the Order of the Undying Sun. Oaths taken in this ceremony are recited from the *Book of the Sun* as a high-ranking member of the church, or in a few cases, Queen Dorytta herself taps the shoulders and head of the prospective knight with their own sword.

Ladites. Followers of Lada always carry out their holy orders at dawn and always from a high point, such as a cliff, hill, or even a roof if necessary. After scripture from the *Golden Book of Ruby Laughter* is quoted, a procession is led to the nearest clinic or infirmary where

POSSESSION COMPLICATIONS

d6 COMPLICATION

- | | |
|---|--|
| 1 | Doors and windows slam open and shut while furniture and other loose items fly around the area. |
| 2 | Candles, torches, and any other open flames or flammable materials flare with intense heat, catching fire and potentially spreading. |
| 3 | Every creature present, including the possessed creature, if any, must make a Constitution saving throw or gain one level of exhaustion. |
| 4 | One present character at random must make a Wisdom saving throw or fall under the effect of a <i>bestow curse</i> spell. The curse lasts for a week or until re-moved by <i>remove curse</i> or similar magic. |
| 5 | The possession moves to another creature or area and requires a successful Wisdom (Perception) check to locate. |
| 6 | No complication |

the newly ordained spend the rest of their day fasting as they work to heal the sick.

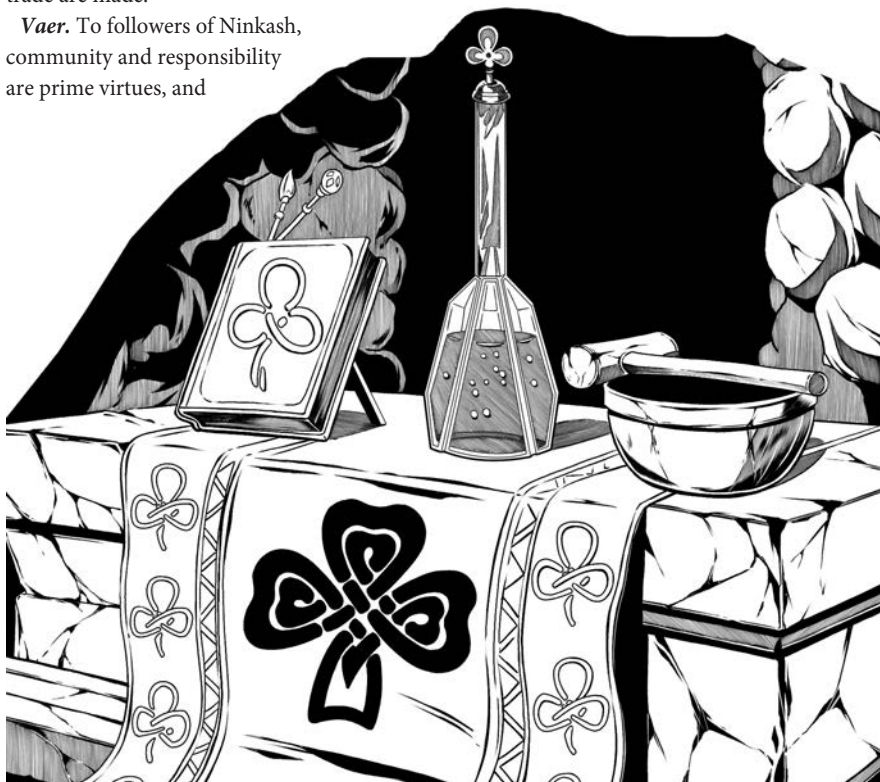
Perunites. In order to satisfy Perun, his priests only conduct their holy orders during stormy weather, preferably as close to thunder and lightning as possible. A bull is slaughtered, and its blood is used to anoint whoever is receiving the holy orders. Then ritualistic combat to first blood is held. If the newly anointed loses the fight, they are excommunicated for their failure and must seek penance.

Ravanites. Serving the patron deity of industry, Rava's priests conduct holy orders for new businesses and temple-approved inventions. More christening than ordainment, bottles of sacred wine, or beer if the proper obeisance has been made to Ninkash, are broken upon new foundations, ribbons are cut, and vows of responsible trade are made.

Vaer. To followers of Ninkash, community and responsibility are prime virtues, and

this reflects in their holy orders. When a dwarf enters the Vaer, they undergo a test to demonstrate their wisdom and worth. The prospective priest must go to every witness present and get them drunk, though not so drunk as to become irresponsible, harmful to themselves or others, or too incoherent to join in the final drinking song of the night. Only once a dwarf has successfully done this are they admitted into the Vaer.

Volundites. Holy orders devoted to Volund differ by region and by who is leading them. The dwarves of the Free Cantons hold a call and response ceremony, hammering tools down on anvils in rhythm and syncopation to concerted chanting. The Khazzaki of the Rothenian Plain, however, wear beautiful, multicolored vestments decorated with Volund's symbols, and they dance and sing well into the night.

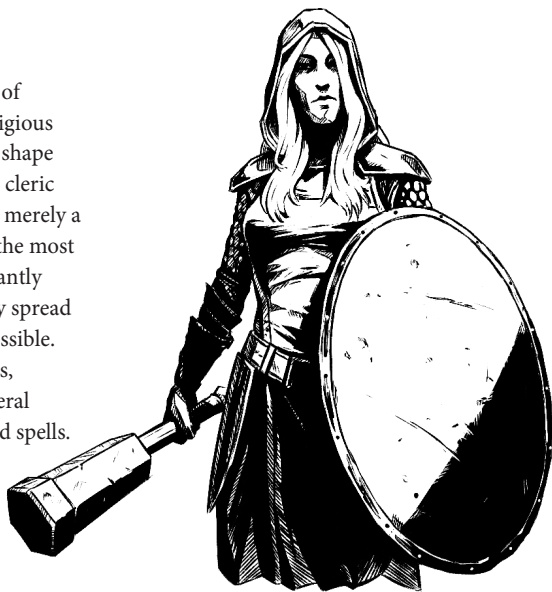


DIVINE INTERVENTIONS: REWARDS FOR THE FAITHFUL

by Rajan Khanna

For most of the clerics and priests of Midgard, the reward for their religious service is divine magic, the ability to shape and alter reality. But while a devoted cleric can gain access to great magic, this is merely a fraction of a given god's power. For the most faithful of priests, those who significantly further their god's goals or effectively spread their faith, additional rewards are possible. These rewards can take various forms, but they generally fall into three general categories: blessings, magic items, and spells.

- **Blessings.** Blessings are generally limited-use powers or abilities that the gods grant to their top priests, and their power varies in relation to the how effective that priest has been. A low-level reward, for example, might be a one-time-use ability while a deity's most worthy champions might receive a permanent ability.
- **Magic Items.** Magic items are yet another reward that faithful divine servants can receive from the gods. In many cases, these magic items have been held by the priesthood, stashed away in churches and sepulchers, guarded until one is called to use them. Still, the most beloved champions may receive their



items from emissaries of the gods or, in rare occasions, the gods themselves. These items can typically be attuned only by worshippers of the god granting them, though there are exceptions.

- **Spells.** Clerics receive divine spells from the gods already, but on occasion a deity will grant a specific follower access to a spell that they normally couldn't cast. These can be new spells or spells from another class's spell list. Some of these new spells are detailed in the following pages.

Earning Rewards. The specifics of what earns one of these rewards depends on the god in question and can vary widely. Typically, however, a reward is given either after a great service or labor or in preparation for one. In the latter case, the blessing, item, or spell, is bestowed to aid the cleric in their efforts.

Note that while this article focuses primarily on clerics, these rewards can be bestowed on any dutiful follower, regardless of class. For these followers, the rewards usually take the form of blessings or magic items, unless the follower is already a spellcaster (in which case spells are a possibility). For wizards, these spells are often given in the form of spell pages, which can be copied into the wizard's spellbook.

Below are examples of these rewards for some of Midgard's gods.

Bastet

The goddess Bastet is known to reward her most faithful in sudden and surprising ways, as befits the goddess of cats. She tends to favor hunters and other bold followers who throw themselves into their actions. Gifted perfumers and alchemists might also receive her favor, as do those who destroy powerful serpents or servants of the god Set.

Bastet most often sends a special black cat messenger, fur glinting like starlight. These cat messengers speak, bearing Bastet's message to the chosen. Items are carried by these cats while blessings and other spells are often bestowed with a touch.

Bastet herself appears only to the worthiest of followers. First as a simple messenger cat—or in the wilds as a lion—before transforming into the cat-headed humanoid she is most often depicted as. In presenting her reward, she also marks the recipient with a scratch, a swipe of a single claw that always draws blood. Those so marked wear the resulting scar with honor for the rest of their days.

BLESSINGS

Instill Essence. Bastet's patronage of perfumers can sometimes take the form of a blessing the goddess rewards to her faithful. After a long rest, you can touch a vessel or container of perfume and instill it with a mote of Bastet's essence. Choose one of the options below. The next creature to wear the perfume before your next long rest gains the selected effect for 1 hour:

- **Imposing Presence.** The creature has advantage on Charisma (Intimidation) checks.
- **Seductive Presence.** The creature has advantage on Charisma (Persuasion) checks.

MAGIC ITEMS

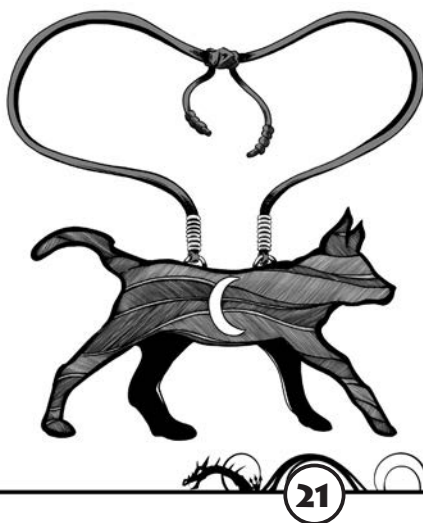
The following item may be presented as a boon from Bastet. Other item rewards may include the *courtesan's allure**, *figurine of wondrous power (golden lions)*, *luring perfume**, or *slippers of the cat**.

(*) see *Vault of Magic*.

BASTET PENDANT

Wondrous Item, Rare (Requires Attunement by a Worshipper of Bastet)

This pendant holds a carved ebony cat with a crescent moon carved in its side. While wearing the pendant, you can use your action



to cast the *polymorph* spell on yourself, transforming into either a **cat** or a **lion**. While you are in one of these forms, you retain your Intelligence, Wisdom, and Charisma scores.

SPELLS

The following spell may be presented as a boon from Bastet. Bastet may also reward her faithful with catfolk spells (see *Southland Players Guide*).

CONJURE CATS

2nd-Level Conjuration | Cleric

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 60 feet

Components: V, S

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 hour

You summon celestial spirits that take feline form and appear in unoccupied spaces that you can see within range. Choose one of the following options for what appears:

- One **lion**
- One **tiger**
- Four **panthers**
- Eight **cats**

Each beast is also considered a celestial, and it disappears when it drops to 0 hit points or when the spell ends.

The summoned felines are friendly to you and your companions. Roll initiative for the summoned creatures as a group, which has its own turns. They obey any verbal commands that you issue to them (no action required by you). If you don't issue any commands to them, they defend themselves from hostile creatures, but otherwise take no actions.

At Higher Levels. When you cast this spell using certain higher-level spell slots, more creatures appear with your chosen summoning option: twice as many with a 4th-level slot, three times as many with a 6th-level slot, and four times as many with an 8th-level slot.

Khors

Since the worship of Khors is in decline, he sometimes pays more attention to his most ardent followers in hopes that they can help inspire others to honor him. Those who bring others into the fold might earn a reward, as might followers who slay powerful demons and devils. Because of Khors's warrior nature, he often rewards paladin worshippers in addition to his clerics, as well as the occasional devout fighter. Khors's rewards often appear in a ray of sunlight or are bestowed by angels with radiant swords.

BLESSINGS

Radiant Weapon. This blessing is bestowed upon a single weapon of your choice. As a bonus action, you can cause the weapon to emit bright light in a 15-foot radius and dim light for an additional 15 feet. The light is sunlight. When you hit a creature with the weapon while it emits sunlight, the creature takes an extra 1d6 radiant damage (undead creatures instead take an extra 2d6 radiant damage).

MAGIC ITEMS

Magic item rewards from Khors include the *dawn shard**, *sun blade*, and *vial of sunlight**.
(* see *Vault of Magic*).

SPELLS

For his most faithful clerics, Khors offers access to the following spells, though often on a limited basis: *branding smite*, *searing sun* (see *Deep Magic*), *sunbeam*, and *sunburst*.

Loki

Loki doesn't pay much attention to his priests or worshippers, instead urging them to act with skill and cleverness while flouting the rules and strictures of society. As such, he is not known to award his followers with much beyond their typical spells. There is, however, one exception—clerics of Loki who

make him laugh. What exactly will make Loki laugh is a matter of great debate. Some believe only the massive and unexpected absurdity of the fickle and chaotic world can elicit such a laugh while others believe it can only be accomplished by plans within plans, schemes within schemes, all laid to defy and belittle the authority of the powerful, be they rulers or gods. In any case, these rare few might receive the following blessing from the trickster god, and it is almost always a one-time use reward.

BLESSINGS

Loki's Ear Serpent. As a bonus action, you can sing a simple melody or speak a simple phrase that works its way into the ears of a nearby creature, enabling you to affect its mind. Choose one creature that you can see and that can hear you, within 60 feet of you. That creature must make a Wisdom saving throw against your spell save DC. On a failed save, the creature has disadvantage on ability checks, attack rolls, and saving throws for 1 minute as the melody or phrase continues to repeat in its mind. In addition, you can choose one of the following effects:

- **Serpent's Bliss.** The creature is charmed by you for 1 hour and is friendly to you and your allies. This charm lasts for the duration, until you or one of your allies attacks the creature, or until you use a bonus action to dismiss it.
- **Serpent's Hiss.** The creature is frightened of you for 10 minutes.
- **Serpent's Kiss.** The creature is poisoned for 1 minute.

On a successful save, the creature has disadvantage on attack rolls, ability checks, and saving throws for 1 minute but doesn't suffer any additional effects.

Nakresh

Nakresh is a dark god, though one who nevertheless likes to reward the best of his followers, who might be rogues or wizards as well as clerics. Nakresh intentionally foment an air of desperate competition among his most devout followers, including the members of the Five, the leaders of his cult. Nakresh often rewards those followers that commit great acts of theft or who discover or steal magical secrets or powerful magic items.

BLESSINGS

Monkey Familiar. Nakresh sometimes rewards his faithful clerics with access to a monkey familiar. You can cast the *find familiar* spell as a ritual without using any material components. When you cast the spell in this way, your familiar always takes the form of a monkey (use the statistics of a **baboon**, though its size is Tiny).

MAGIC ITEMS

The following item may be presented as a boon from Nakresh.

GLOVES OF NAKRESH

Wondrous Item, Rare (Requires Attunement by a Rogue or Wizard who Worships Nakresh)

These gloves appear to be made from thin, brown leather, or maybe even the skin of a humanoid. They are unadorned save for the images of stars painted on the palms.

While attuned to these gloves, you can use a bonus action to cause a pair of illusory arms to appear in place of your normal arms while your real arms and hands become invisible. Objects that you carry in your hands also become invisible as long as your arms and hands are. While these illusory arms are in place, you gain the following benefits:

- Dexterity (Sleight of Hand) checks are made with advantage.
- If you have the Sneak Attack ability, you don't need advantage on the attack



roll to use your Sneak Attack against a creature if you are within 5 feet of it and you don't have disadvantage on the attack roll.

- While casting a spell, you can conceal the somatic and material components of that spell.

The illusory arms last for a minute or until you use a bonus action to dismiss them. You must complete a long rest before you can use the gloves again.



SPELLS

The following spell may be presented as a boon from Nakresh. In addition, Nakresh can share with his followers the *scattered images* spell (see *Demon Cults & Secret Societies*).

WALL OF HANDS

6th-Level Conjurat[i]on | Cleric

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 120 feet

Components: V, S, M

Duration: Concentration, up to 1 minute

A wall of writhing, animated humanoid hands appears at a point you choose within range. The wall appears within range on a solid surface and lasts for the duration. You can choose to make the wall up to 60 feet long, 10 feet high, and 5 feet thick. The hands reach out from both sides of the wall. The wall blocks line of sight.

If the wall cuts through a creature's space when it appears, the creature is pushed to one side of the wall (your choice). Any creature that enters a space within 5 feet of the wall or starts its turn within 5 feet of the wall must make a Strength saving throw. On a failed save, the creature is grappled and has disadvantage on ability checks and attack rolls until the start of its next turn. If a creature succeeds on the saving throw, it is not grappled but still has disadvantage on attack rolls and ability check rolls.

Additionally, you can cast a spell with a range of touch and have the spell originate from a point on the wall instead of from you.

Ninkash

The Mother of Beer likes to reward those of her followers who excel both at the brewing of beer and the ability to bring people together (often over that beer). Some of her most favored worshippers start breweries and alehouses. Ninkash speaks to her followers through ale, often bestowing her rewards through drunken visions.

BLESSINGS

Because beer and ale are temporary, enjoyed in the consumption, Ninkash's blessings are almost always temporary, often single-use abilities, with the exception of the following blessing.

Ale-chemy. You can hold a container of beer or ale and use an action to infuse it with the blessings of Ninkash. Choose one of the following options. That effect takes place when a creature consumes the infused beverage within the next hour:

- **Aid.** The creature has advantage on the first attack roll or skill check that it makes in the next 24 hours.
- **Fortify.** The creature has a +1 bonus to all saving throws for 1 hour.
- **Heal.** The creature regains 1d8 hit points.

MAGIC ITEMS

The following item may be presented as a boon from Ninkash. In addition, Ninkash sometimes rewards followers with a *wand of fermentation* (see *Vault of Magic*).

BOTTOMLESS TANKARD

Wondrous Item, Very Rare (Requires Attunement by a Follower of Ninkash)

While beer is meant to be consumed and not kept for long periods of time, this tankard allows you to store multiple varieties of beer or other liquids in it. Five magical runes are inscribed upon this tankard. If you pour a liquid into the tankard and press

one of the runes, it is transported into an extradimensional space. Pressing that rune again will fill the tankard with that liquid. Once all five runes are used, no more liquid can be stored within the tankard until one of the runes is emptied.



SPELLS

The following spell may be presented as a boon from Ninkash.

TOAST THE GODDESS

3rd-Level Transmutation | Cleric

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: Touch

Components: V, S, M (a full tankard of beer or ale)

Duration: Instantaneous

When you cast this spell, you create six full tankards of beer or ale that resemble the tankard and beverage used in the casting. Creatures that consume one of the tankards within the next hour gain temporary hit points equal to your spellcasting ability modifier.

Ogun

Ogun most often rewards his followers in the guise of the Keeper of Keys and Dungeons. Explorers, those who open closed doors, can gain his favor as can effective wardens and

jailors, those who protect civilized people from criminals and monsters. Blessings and spells often seem to be “unlocked” inside the recipient’s mind while magic items often appear when the recipient opens or unlocks a container or door.

BLESSINGS

Door Warden. This blessing allows the recipient to cast the *arcane lock* or *knock* spells (once per day each) without the need for components.

Lock Whisperer. This blessing grants you advantage on checks using thieves’ tools made to pick or otherwise manipulate locks.

MAGIC ITEMS

The following item may be presented as a boon from Ninkash. In addition, Ogun sometimes rewards his most faithful followers with the following items: *burglar’s lock and key**, *chime of opening*, *dimensional shackles*, *iron bands of binding*, *seneschal’s gloves**, and *skeleton key**.

(*) see *Vault of Magic*.

INFINITY KEY

Wondrous Item, Very Rare (Requires Attunement by a Follower of Ogun)

This key can take various forms, from an old key threaded with verdigris to a shiny new one, but its abilities remain the same regardless of its appearance. While attuned to the key, you can use an action to insert the key into any door lock and “pair” the key to that door.

If you later use an action to insert the key into a different door lock on the same plane of existence as the paired door, the current door will open to the location the paired door led to instead of its usual destination. This effect lasts for an hour. Any creature or object that passes through the door will end up where the original, paired door led. After the hour is finished, the key will not operate until the next dawn.

SPELLS

Ogun often grants his clerics access to the *arcane lock* and *knock* spells and sometimes to the *door of the far traveler* spell (see *Tome of Heroes*).

Rava

Rava is already known for rewarding her faithful by making them into gearforged, but she also rewards her other devout followers.

BLESSINGS

Spark of Creation (Usable by Gearforged Only). While typically Rava oversees new creations, some of that same creative power can be used to repair damaged gearforged. As a gearforged with this blessing, you can use a bonus action to immediately regain 50 hit points of damage. This blessing is usually a one-time use.

MAGIC ITEMS

The following item may be presented as a boon from Rava. In addition, Rava has also been known to reward followers with items such as the *clockwork mace of divinity** or other clockwork magic items as well as the *loom of fate** and *quill of scribing**.
(*) see *Vault of Magic*.

ARIADNE'S TOOLS

Wondrous Item, Very Rare (Requires Attunement by a Worshipper of Rava)

These tools are identical to a set of weaver's tools except that they are of a higher quality and resistant to rust and wear. When you use these to make an ability check, you have advantage on that check.

While attuned to the tools, when you complete a long rest, you can roll a d20 and write down the result. Once before your next long rest, you can substitute that number for one ability check roll, attack roll, or saving

throw roll. If you use this number on an ability check made with the tools, you can also double your proficiency bonus for the check.

SPELLS

In addition to the *soulforging* spell itself (see *Midgard Heroes Handbook*), Rava also can reward her followers with a variety of clockwork spells if they don't have access to those already.

Sabateus

Sabateus typically rewards his followers who recover hidden and ancient lore or who teach the knowledge of the stars and constellations to others. In addition to clerics, druids of the Circle of Stars also honor Sabateus and may be rewarded for their service.

BLESSINGS

Child of the Night. This blessing grants the following abilities:

- When traveling at night, your travel pace is doubled.
- You can always tell which way is north at night
- You gain darkvision to a range of 60 feet.
- You have advantage on Wisdom (Perception) checks when the moon or stars are visible.

MAGIC ITEMS

Sabateus sometimes rewards his faithful followers with magic items such as the *ring of shooting stars* or *robe of stars*.

SPELLS

The following spells are sometimes granted to Sabateus's most devoted clerics: *guiding star**, *shield of starlight**, *starburst**, *starfall**, *star's heart**, and *summon star**.

(*) see *Deep Magic*.

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